national period, state claims and a national ideology of racial inclusiveness allowed powerholders to marginalize and prohibit black organizations, movements, and claims for rights.

For Moore, official antipathy towards and repression of explicitly black political consciousness and organizing undermined any supposed attempts at creating racial equality. “It was out of the question for Blacks themselves to define the content of their own oppression, or define the terms of their ethnic emancipation,” Moore writes. “The Castro leadership would resist and even repress attempts by black dissenters to force the issue into the open.”[17]

De la Fuente and Sawyer give more credit to the state projects that “created significant opportunities in other areas of social, political and economic life for blacks.”[18] They also agree, however, that despite these successes, a complex combination of factors led racial inequality to resurface in even more virulent form in the Special Period, as I will discuss in the next chapter.

Gender

The Revolution’s push to overcome gender inequalities in some ways paralleled, and in other ways differed from, its approach to racial inequality. Structural reforms were key: creating economic opportunity for women, especially poor women, and socializing many of the domestic tasks that fell disproportionately on women. But the revolutionary leadership also saw sexist beliefs and ideologies as more of a problem than it did in the case of race. Women were encouraged to form their own organization, the Federation of Cuban Women, under the auspices of the Communist Party, and identify and challenge the problems that faced them specifically as women.

As in the case of race, the structural changes did significantly improve the situation of many Cuban women. In addition, ongoing, explicit campaigns targeted sexist attitudes and gender inequalities. The FMC, like other mass organizations such as the CDRs, really played a dual role as both a bottom-up and a top-down organization. On one hand, it was a